

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The Lancashire–Yorkshire Rail Spine Renaissance Programme

**A Public–Private Partnership to Create a 125mph Regional
Railway Linking Blackpool, Preston, Blackburn and Leeds**

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management (EVWM) proposes the creation of:

The Lancashire–Yorkshire Connectivity Fund (LYCF)

A long-term infrastructure investment partnership to upgrade the railway corridor:

Blackpool → Preston → Blackburn → Burnley → Bradford → Leeds

into a high-capacity, electrified regional railway.

The strategic objective:

Create a northern economic spine connecting the Irish Sea coast, Lancashire manufacturing towns, Pennine communities and Yorkshire's financial centre.

The project would transform a historically fragmented rail network into a single economic corridor.

The upgraded route would function as:

- a regional express railway
- a commuter network
- a tourism corridor
- a freight route
- a housing growth catalyst

Existing transport strategies have already identified improved connections between East Lancashire, Preston, Manchester and Leeds as a strategic priority.

1. Strategic Vision

The Northern Coastal-to-Capital Corridor

Current economic geography:

Blackpool
|
Preston
|
Blackburn
|
Burnley
|
Bradford
|
Leeds

Future:

Lancashire–Yorkshire Metro Regional Railway

A system similar to:

- German Regional Express
- Swiss InterCity regional links
- Dutch Randstad rail

2. The Economic Problem

Lancashire and West Yorkshire contain:

- millions of people
- universities
- manufacturing
- engineering
- tourism
- financial services

However, east-west connectivity remains weak.

The result:

- smaller labour markets
- fewer business connections
- lower productivity

A worker in Blackburn should realistically be able to access:

- Preston jobs
 - Leeds finance sector
 - Blackpool tourism economy
 - Bradford manufacturing
-

3. Proposed Investment

Total Programme Cost

£2.5 billion

25-year PPP

Funding:

Source	Amount
EVWM Infrastructure Fund	£500m
UK pension funds	£1bn
Rail investors	£500m
Government partnership	£500m

4. Infrastructure Programme

Phase One

Blackpool–Preston Upgrade

Investment:

£400 million

Current situation:

Blackpool and Preston already have electrification infrastructure, and proposals such as Cottam Parkway demonstrate demand for better connectivity around the Preston–Blackpool corridor.

Works:

- additional capacity
 - faster junctions
 - improved signalling
 - new stations
 - platform extensions
-

New stations:

- Cottam Parkway
 - Preston West
 - Fylde Coast growth stations
-

Target times:

Route	Current	Future
Blackpool–Preston	~25 mins	15 mins

Phase Two

Preston–Blackburn Fast Rail Upgrade

Investment:

£500 million

Works:

- double-track improvements
 - curve easing
 - signalling upgrades
 - electrification preparation
-

Target:

Frequent services:

every 15 minutes

Journey:

Route	Current	Future
Preston–Blackburn	~25 mins	15 mins

Phase Three

Blackburn–Burnley–Bradford Modernisation

Investment:

£900 million

This is the key transformational section.

Works:

Electrification

Full electrification of the corridor.

Track Upgrades

Allow:

100–125mph running where geography permits.

Capacity

New passing loops.

More frequent services.

Target:

Route	Current	Future
Blackburn–Burnley	~35 mins	20 mins
Burnley–Bradford	~70 mins	35 mins

Phase Four

Bradford–Leeds Capacity Enhancement

Investment:

£700 million

Works:

- additional tracks where required
- junction improvements
- station upgrades
- integration with wider TransPennine improvements

Leeds is already undergoing significant rail capacity upgrades through wider regional programmes.

Target:

Route	Current	Future
Bradford–Leeds	20–30 mins	15 mins

5. Rolling Stock Strategy

EVWM proposes:

Northern Regional Express Fleet

Fleet:

80 electric multiple units

Specification:

- 125mph capability
 - high acceleration
 - large capacity
 - luggage space
 - bicycle storage
 - premium commuter seating
-

Brand:

Lancashire–Yorkshire Express

Service pattern:

Every 15 minutes:

Blackpool

↓

Preston

↓

Blackburn

↓

Burnley

↓

Bradford

↓

Leeds

6. Tourism Opportunity

The railway connects major tourism assets:

Blackpool

- seaside tourism
- entertainment
- conferences

↓

Lancashire Countryside

↓

Yorkshire Dales gateway

↓

Leeds

- shopping

- culture
 - finance
-

Potential:

+1 million additional visitor journeys annually.

7. Freight Opportunity

The corridor also supports:

- manufacturing freight
- parcels
- logistics

Connecting:

Blackpool port opportunities

↓

Lancashire industry

↓

Yorkshire distribution

Potential freight benefits:

- fewer HGV movements
 - better resilience
 - lower logistics costs
-

8. Economic Impact

Investment:

£2.5 billion

Construction Employment

Estimated:

20,000 job-years

Permanent Employment

Rail operations:

2,000 jobs

Supply chain:

5,000 jobs

GDP Impact

The economic mechanism:

Better transport

↓

larger labour market

↓

higher productivity

↓

business investment

Conservative Estimate

Annual regional GVA uplift:

£750 million

Growth Scenario

With housing and industrial development:

£1.5 billion annual uplift

9. Housing Impact

The railway enables:

Transit-oriented development.

Potential:

20,000–30,000 new homes

around:

- Preston
 - Blackburn
 - Burnley
 - Bradford
 - Leeds outskirts
-

10. Investment Returns

Revenue sources:

Passenger Revenue

Higher ridership.

Station Development

Commercial:

- retail
 - offices
 - housing
-

Land Value Capture

New development around stations.

Target:

6–8% infrastructure return

11. Wider Strategic Role

This railway becomes the missing link between:

West Coast Main Line

London–Glasgow

and

TransPennine Network

Liverpool–Manchester–Leeds–York

It creates:

The Northern Crossrail Effect

Not a single city project.

A regional economic system.

Final Recommendation

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management recommends establishing:

The Lancashire–Yorkshire Rail Spine Investment Partnership

A £2.5 billion PPP to create a modern electrified regional railway.

The strategic objective:

Transform:

Blackpool, Preston, Blackburn and Leeds from separate economies

into:

One connected northern economic corridor.

The investment philosophy:

Fast rail creates larger markets.

Larger markets create productivity.

Productivity creates regional wealth.

This railway would become the backbone of a new Lancashire–Yorkshire economic region.